OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Mayor White asked whether she spoke for Council in Great Southern Forest video

Sent 5 November 2026 · To Shoalhaven City Council · Response requested by 19 November 2026

OPEN LETTER

To: Cr Patricia White, Mayor of Shoalhaven
Copy: Mr Andrew Constance, Chief Executive Officer, Shoalhaven City Council
From: Stephen Prothero, Eye on Shoalhaven Council
Date: 5 November 2026
Subject: Were you speaking for Council in the Great Southern Forest video, and will Council act on statements the record does not support?

STATUS OF THIS LETTER
This is a public open letter. It is published by Eye on Shoalhaven Council as a matter of public interest journalism.

Part A is a set of questions put to a public official in the same way a journalist puts questions to an elected representative. The Mayor may answer all, some or none of them, in whatever form and at whatever time she chooses. Part B is a request to Council, made through the Mayor and copied to the Chief Executive, that Council consider and report on the action it will take. This letter is not a Code of Conduct complaint and does not allege a breach of the Code of Conduct by any person. It is not an access application under the Government Information (Public Access) Act 2009 (NSW).

Replies will be published in full. If no reply is received, that will be recorded as it stands.

Dear Mayor White,

A video clip about the proposed Great Southern Forest National Park is circulating. I understand that you are the speaker. In it, as transcribed, the speaker says:

“We have been shut out of the process. Completely shut out as a council, there’s a whole world of hurt coming our way that our residents, our communities do not deserve.”
Under section 226 of the Local Government Act 1993 the Mayor is the principal member and spokesperson of the governing body.

A Mayor who says “we” and “as a council” is therefore heard as speaking for Council.

On the record I have been able to find, several of these statements are not supported:

there is no NSW Government position on a proposal that came from the community, no government assessment or consultation under way for Council to be shut out of, and

no evidence that the National Parks Association is acting other than openly as the proponent.
Nor is there any data on the political or environmental views of the 69,624 volunteers in the NSW Rural Fire Service or the SES volunteers who fight fires.
Part A. Questions to the Mayor
1. Capacity. Were you speaking on behalf of Shoalhaven City Council in the clip, or as an individual councillor?
2. Basis. If you were speaking for Council, on what basis? Please identify any Council resolution (number and date), delegation, or other instrument you rely on.
3. Authorisation. Were you authorised to speak for Council on the Great Southern Forest proposal? If so, by whom, when and in what form? Please provide a copy.
4. If you were not authorised. Will you say publicly that the statements were your personal views and not a position of Council?
5. "Shut out". What exactly has Council been shut out of? Please identify the process, the date, the person or agency that excluded Council, and any correspondence in which Council sought involvement and was refused.
6. Evidence. What is the evidence for the statements that the National Parks Association has "gotten in" to community groups, that people are "being misled", and that people who support the park or belong to community groups are not among those who fight fires?
7. Origin of the clip. Who recorded and published the clip, and did you approve its release?
8. Party membership. Are you a member of the Shooters, Fishers and Farmers Party, or are you considering becoming a member? I ask because you hold public office, the clip addresses issues on which that party campaigns, and the public is entitled to know the affiliations of those who speak for Council. If you are not, a one-line answer will settle it.
Part B. Request to Council
I ask that Council, through the Councillors and the Chief Executive:

9. determine and publicly state whether the statements in the clip were made on behalf of Council and, if so, under what authority;
10. if they were not authorised, publicly clarify that they are not a position of Council, so that residents are not left to assume they are;
11. if the statements were presented as Council's, correct the public record on the points above that are not supported, in particular that Council has been "completely shut out" of a process; and
12. advise me in writing what action Council will take, and by what date.
I understand there may be policy issues that the Councillors may wish to raise with the Chief Executive Officer.

I ask for a reply by 19 November 2026.

Yours sincerely,

Stephen Prothero

Eye on Shoalhaven Council
